1.3 African-American Soldiers

Sometimes in war, people put goals ahead of prejudices. During the Civil War, the U.S. military accepted African-American soldiers into its ranks. Defeating the South had become more important than excluding fellow Americans from military service.

MAIN IDEA In 1863, African Americans began to join U.S. military units and proved to be valuable soldiers for the Union.

AFRICAN AMERICANS JOIN THE FIGHT

When the Civil War first began, many free African-American men rushed to **enlist** in, or join, the Union Army, but they were turned away. A 1792 law barred African Americans from joining the U.S. military. At first, members of Lincoln's administration resisted changing this prohibition. But the Emancipation Proclamation reversed the law with its provision that African-American men "will be received into the armed service of the United States," a critical development that affected the war's outcome.

By the end of the Civil War, African-American soldiers in the U.S. Army totaled nearly 180,000, or about 10 percent of total Union enlistments. Additionally, 19,000 African Americans served in the U.S. Navy. African-American troops faced the same danger and fought with as much commitment as white soldiers, but they were not treated equally.

The army assigned African-American soldiers to segregated units commanded by white officers. African-American soldiers received lower wages than most white soldiers until June 1864, when Congress granted equal pay to African-American military units.

Like all 19th-century American women, African-American women were barred from enlisting in the army. Still, some African-American women, including Harriet Tubman, served as nurses, spies, and scouts. As you have read, Tubman led people to freedom on the Underground Railroad. Tubman also worked as a nurse and scouted behind Confederate lines for the Union's 2nd South Carolina Volunteers. In 1863, she helped free 727 slaves at one time during the Combahee River Raid. That raid was the single largest liberation of slaves in American history.

THE 54TH MASSACHUSETTS REGIMENT

In February 1863, the governor of Massachusetts issued the first formal call for African-American soldiers to join the U.S. Army. He selected the **54th Massachusetts** infantry regiment under the command of Colonel **Robert Gould Shaw**, a white officer. In just two weeks, more than 1,000 African Americans enlisted. Charles and Lewis Douglass, two sons of Frederick Douglass, were among them.

On July 18, 1863, the 54th Massachusetts prepared to storm **Fort Wagner**, which guarded the Port of Charleston, South Carolina. At dusk, Shaw gathered 600 of his men on a narrow strip of sand just outside Fort Wagner's walls. He told them, "I want you to prove yourselves. The eyes of thousands will look on what you do tonight."

As night fell, Shaw led his men over the walls of the fort. They were met by 1,700 Confederate soldiers waiting inside the fort. The brutal hand-to-hand combat that followed took its toll: 281 of the 600 charging soldiers were killed, wounded, or captured. Shaw himself was shot in the chest and died instantly. The 54th lost the battle at Fort Wagner, but its valor, or courage, was beyond

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Smithsonian National Gallery of Art, Washington, D.C.

In 1897, Augustus Saint-Gaudens unveiled his 14-year project of honoring the members of the 54th Massachusetts in a bronze relief called the Robert Gould Shaw Memorial. The sculpture depicts the regiment marching down Beacon Street in Boston, on its way to fight Confederate troops in South Carolina. The following year in Paris, Saint-Gaudens exhibited a second version of the memorial made of plaster and covered with bronze metallic paint. Today, the bronze-painted sculpture shown above is housed at the Smithsonian National Gallery of Art in Washington, D.C. The original sculpture is located at the Boston African American National Historic Site on Beacon Street, across the street from the Massachusetts State House. An inscription on the Boston memorial reads, "Together they gave to the nation and the world undying proof that Americans of African descent possess the pride, courage, and devotion of the patriot soldier."

question. For his bravery in the fight, **William H. Carney** became the first African American to receive the Congressional Medal of Honor.

For the next two years, the 54th Massachusetts took part in a number of sieges in South Carolina, Georgia, and Florida. The service and bravery of its members helped to win acceptance for other African-American regiments and solidified their importance in the war effort. Despite increased African-American enlistment, the need for more soldiers in both the North and the South grew.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** Why did the Union wait until after the Emancipation Proclamation to enlist African Americans in the army?
2. **DRAW CONCLUSIONS** Why did the 54th Massachusetts gain great respect in the Union Army despite losing its first battle?
3. **ANALYZE LANGUAGE USE** What made the words Colonel Shaw used with his troops before the battle at Fort Wagner particularly effective?

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